

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Fall Series 1
Painting the Stars ~ A Renaissance of Wonder
6 September 2026

LVF Updated Saturday 2pm

Preaching: LVF

Worship Leading: ML & Betsy Sullenger

Strips of paper in programs for prayers

Tech needs: piano for offertory, amplified, one solo mic, two monitors

Organ Prelude-Concert

Improvisation on SALZBURG and BUNESSAN

Paraphrase of Tomaso Vitali's Chaconne in G minor

Meditation on "Cao Cung Lên" (Dúc/Xyên, adapted by C. Bull)

A Tribute to Dolly Parton (Dolly Parton, arr. C. Bull)

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Chiming of the Hour

[Michael and Betsy center chancel]

Welcome

ML

Good morning and welcome to FCCLA! We give thanks for your presence here and your presence online, as we welcome all from near and far. We are a community that encourages and celebrates the fullness of who we are, a community where we are free to love whom we love, and where we are equipped to explore faith and spirituality at our own pace.

Today, we open our fall series, *Painting the Stars*, as Rev. Laura explores the theme, *A Renaissance of Wonder*. We also celebrate the life and example of Dolly Parton through music and word. And we pause in honor of Labor Day to celebrate the labor movement that has fought and continues its fight for fairness and justice, living wages, and healthy workplaces that nurture belonging for all and rest for workers.

In this time, we open our whole selves now to wonder and to all that awaits us here, as we share these Words of Gathering.

Words of Gathering

ML and Betsy

Betsy: We gather now,
harvesters of an all-pervasive grace,
unexpected benefactors of the deed
to this great and glorious cosmic inheritance.

Michael: We, the walking, waking stars, ablaze with
wonder,
imagination,
and hope,
gather to remember three words: *kinship* with all
that is;
debt, that can only be paid forward;
gift, sacred
mantra of the humble.

Betsy: Creation,
the great and glorious sacrifice of abundance, asks
in return-
only-
that we shed our entitled egos
and drop to our knees,
uttering a single, simple prayer
that changes everything:
'Thank you.' [bsanguin]

Michael: *Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Creation.*

*Hymn of Creation

SALZBURG

Let the whole creation cry, "Glory be to God on high!"
Heaven and earth, awake and sing, to your God your praises bring.
Sun and moon, uplift your voice, night and stars, in God rejoice;
sunshine, darkness, cloud, and storm, rain and snow in praise perform.

Chant in honor, ocean fair; earth, soft rushing through the air;
birds, with morn and dew elate, sing with joy at heaven's gate.
Let the blossoms of the earth join the universal mirth;
men and women, young and old, raise the anthem manifold.

You to whom the arts belong, add your voices to the song;
bards of knowledge and of law, to the glorious circle draw.
From the north to southern pole let the mighty chorus roll:
"Holy, holy, holy," cry; "Glory be to God on high!"

[Michael center chancel]

Prayer of Awareness*ML**

Holy One,
 sometimes we forget
 that we carry around
 in our bodies,
 and in our luminous minds,
 the entire universe.

Illumed One,
 despite knowing that each carbon atom
 in our blood and firing neuron in our brain
 came from ancient stars,
 we still ignore our own radiance.

Too often, Mysterious One,
 we cannot see the miracles
 that are right before our eyes.

*Help us, O God, in this time
 to see your light shining upon us
 and help us God to look to the stars
 so that we might see your light around us,
 among us, and within us -
 on this day,
 and on all the days to come.
 Amen and Amen!*

[All turn towards choir]

***Introit**

Light of a Clear Blue Morning
Laude, Dr. Fahad Siadat, Conductor

Dolly Parton/arr. David Harris

[Betsy to lectern]

The Lord's Prayer*Betsy**

Let us now join our voices in this Lord's Prayer...

*Weaver of Life, Ancient and Unfolding,
 How sacred is your Presence!
 We lean on your guidance.
 We seek your love.
 We open to your transformation.
 Provide us bread in body and spirit
 to sustain us in faith and solidarity.
 Companion us with grace
 as we seek to live lives of forgiveness and compassion,
 repair and accountability.*

*We remember those who have supported us
as we seek to support others
in all the mess and glory of this human journey.
Guard our minds and hearts from the temptation of domination
and turn our loyalty away from the systems of evil.
For the whole cosmos hums with your wisdom.
Everything that lives, returns to your care.
Our thanks and honor to you,
Gracious Web of Existence,
Our Source and our Home.
Amen and Amen.*

[enfleshed]

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Michael to center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

ML

In the rising of the sun and its setting,
in the glow of the moon and its seasons,
in the infinity of space and its shining stars,
we experience God with gratitude.

This morning, may we know the harmony of heaven
in the relationships of earth
and may we know the expanse of its mystery
within ourselves and within each other.

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are now invited to share this greeting with those near you.

Please be seated

[Betsy to lectern]

Readings from the Wisdom of Our Tradition

Betsy

from the Psalms Psalm 19:1-4

A Reading from the Psalms...

The heavens herald your glory, O God,
and the skies display your handiwork.
Day after day they tell their story,
and night after night they reveal
the depth of their understanding.
Without speech, without words,
without even an audible voice,
their cry echoes through all the world,
and their message reaches the ends of the earth.

from the Prayer of Azariah

And please join us in this reading from the Prayer of Azariah...

**Blessed are you in the high heavens, O God.*

Let the sun and moon praise you.

Let the stars and all that shines with glory praise you.

For you are the God of all creation.

This is the witness of the people.

Thanks be to God!

*The Prayer of Azariah is a passage that appears after [Daniel 3:23](#) in [Roman Catholic](#) and [Eastern Orthodox](#) Bibles, as well as in the ancient Greek [Septuagint](#) translation.

[Christoph short transition ML center chancel]

Prayers with the People

ML

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

In this time of silence and prayer, we begin with the words of another prophet of love that passed last week, the great Wendell Berry.

*Breathe the unconditional breath, the unconditioned air. Shun electric wire.
Communicate slowly. Live a three-dimensioned life; stay away from screens. Stay away
from anything that obscures the place it is in. There are no unsacred places; there are
only sacred places and desecrated places.*

Here, in these moments, we name this place, and our place within it, sacred. We breathe deeply of the peace it offers and the peace for which our hearts, minds, spirits, and bodies, so desperately long. Our screens tell us with regularity of our world's suffering—whether from environmental destruction, war, violence, and the myriad forms injustice takes—we name each of those places, and others' places within them, sacred too.

As we share these moments of silence, we are invited to write these prayers of our hearts, for our lives and the life of our world, on the slips of paper in our programs. If you are online, please share your prayers by emailing prayers@fccla.org.

Then, as the music begins, we are invited to come forward to share our prayers here in the bowl, and to light candles signifying our prayers, for ourselves, those we love and hold dear - and for the life of the world.

Let us now be in silence, together.

Silence

[Christoph transition out of silence as people come forward to offer prayers and light candles]

[Michael center chancel when all are seated]

Prayer of Our Hearts

Eternal Mystery, Heaven's Presence,
Stillest Breath and Deepest Sigh,
we open our hearts
to the presence of Who We Are in this place.

Each of us brings life to this day's possibilities.
We bring hope, or despair,
eagerness or malaise,
joy or sorrow
and with these things we paint the skies above us.

silence

May the beauty of life's fullness unfold in our hearts
that we may loosen
the grip of the mundane on our lives.
May the richness of mystery unfold in our minds
that we may let go of our need for proof.
May the possibility of newness and light
be present to us
that we may unfold the wings of our faith
and soar as into a world changed by our possibilities.

***May we see in the skies we have painted
the collective beauty of the world
and the miracle of our presence in it.***

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

[Christoph transition for choir]

Meditation Anthem

O Virtus Sapientiae
 Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Conductor*

Hildegard von Bingen

[Christoph transition Laura to pulpit, choir to seats]

Sermon

A Renaissance of Wonder

LVF

[Christoph transition Betsy to lectern]

Invitation to Generosity

Betsy

This morning, we are here to remember
 the harmony of heaven in the relationships of earth,
 and to respond to the expanse of this mystery
 within ourselves and within each other.

Our offerings and gifts are an essential part of this remembrance.
 We give thanks to God for this life we are privileged to share,
 and we give from our resources to ensure that this community
 continues to grow in its commitment
 of being a place where all God's children
 are celebrated and loved.

Today, we share our offerings for our Food@First program, which, twice each
 month, allows us to nurture community with our neighbors, as we share fresh
 groceries and food grown and harvested from our Community Gardens and Urban Farm.
 We also share diapers for over 80 young families and older adults. Your gifts to
 Food@First makes this work possible and - makes a difference in many people's lives.

Thank you for your ongoing generosity through your financial support, your time, your
 gifts, and talents.

FOOD AT FIRST QR Code

Offertory Anthem

Silent Noon

Ralph Vaughan Williams

Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Soloist*, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Piano*

text: Dante Gabriel Rossetti

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
 let the Creator's praise arise!

Alleluia! Alleluia!
 Your name shall sound and praises soar
 till suns shall rise and set no more.
 Alleluia! Alleluia!
 Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
 [adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Betsy to lectern toward end of doxology]

***Prayer of Offering**

Betsy

O God of the Universe,
 we give thanks today
 for the Driving Force
 at work in our world
 that becomes visible
 in extravagant generosity
 and celebration of being.

We rejoice in the awareness
 that we are co-creators with you
 of this life,
 and we pray for the grace
 to accept its responsibilities.

*Help us in these days to work with
 the Spirit of Life so that we may
 give breath to your dream
 for our lives, and for our world.
 We pray this in the Way of the One
 who taught us how to see.
 Amen and Amen!*

Please be seated

[Laura & Michael center chancel]

Life at First Church**ML & LVF**

ML: We will welcome new members next Sunday! Please let me know if you'd like to join. You'll have another opportunity to join in December this year and, in November, we'll have a Discovering Belonging at 1st Church gathering. This is not required, so if you'd like to be a part of next week, please do!

LVF: Sanctuary (This Wednesday, 9.9)

ML: Fall gatherings begin: Book Group (Tuesdays, beginning 9.15), Men's Group (9.23), Not Your Grandma's Bible Study (9.24), Music in the Gardens Event (9.26), Mother Agapia at 1st Church (9.26), Collaboratives New Year Celebration (9.27)!

LVF: Coffee Hour today | Also, our Food@First team serves today.

Words of Blessing**LVF**

The blessings of heaven,
the blessings of the earth,
 the blessings of sea and sky.
On those we love this day
 and on every human family
the gifts of heaven,
 the gifts of earth,
the gifts of sea and sky.
Amen and Amen!

Choral Response*To Sit and Dream*

Dr. Rosephanye Powell
 Text: Langston Hughes

Hymn for the JourneyCome See the Fullness***BUNESSAN**

God the Creator gave in abundance
 All of the wonder we now behold;
 Colors of glory, everyday beauty,
 Echo the story of God's deep love.

Bold as the sunlight, tender as nightfall,
 Love shaped the heav'n's height; love filled the seas.
 Love formed the flowers, called for the living;
 Marked out the hours of time to be.

Come, see the fullness – life we've been given;
 Beauty and promise, mystr'y and hope.
 Laughter and weeping, vision and purpose;
 Friends for the keeping, strength for the road.

- lyrics by Peggy A. Haymnes

[Michael center chancel]

Postlude

Improvisation on “9 to 5” (Dolly Parton, adapted for organ by C. Bull)

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Inside The Music Dr. Ianthe Marini

Today we begin a new series exploring our own creation from the matter of the universe and the dust of stars: our interconnectivity with the particles that have existed before us and will continue with our passing. This great unifying force is a comforting and expansive thought. And so, there is no more fitting start to our morning than the well-loved comforting call from one of the world’s great unifiers: Dolly Parton. “*Everything’s gonna be alright. It’s gonna be ok*”, she reminds us even in her departing, through her stalwart and tireless legacy of standing brazenly and boldly in solidarity with the marginalized, and giving generously of her resources to people in need. “*There is a light in the clear blue morning*” when we commit to helping it shine.

A Renaissance of Wonder is further heard through the sonic universe created by the trailblazing mystic, thinker, artist, poet, and creative Hildegard von Bingen. Her mysticism of the 12th century reawakens our own heightened sense of presence within and throughout the universe even now. *O virtus sapientiae - O Power of Wisdom*, we call, as we seek to connect to that bold present! Which then invites us to be aware of that which surrounds us, celebrated in the Rossetti poem set so powerfully by Ralph Vaughan Williams and sung by Dr. Siadat and Dr. Bull—“*your eyes smile peace. Tis visible silence: still as the hourglass. When twofold silence was the song of love.*” A renaissance—a reawakening—often comes with its utmost clarity in the living silence—the privilege to rest and to observe. And finally, we sing a Langston Hughes text from the Harlem Renaissance set powerfully by Dr. Rosephanye Powell, a dream for his enslaved ancestors to have the freedom “*To sit. To sit and dream. To sit and dream about the world.*”